

Considering the price, I can't complain, but the Realme Buds Air 8 does a better job here, too. Realme gives a voice enhancement option as well.

Besides noise handling, the mics on the Nord Buds 4 earbuds do a good job for calls. OnePlus underlines the use of AI to enhance clarity.

BATTERY LIFE

Like the OnePlus Nord Buds 4 Pro, the standard model also delivers a day-long battery life. During my testing, with ANC off and music (FLAC format) continuously playing at 80 per cent volume, the Nord Buds 4 ran for 11 hours and 12 minutes. And so in everyday use, it is but obvious that I never actually managed to drain them completely in a single working day. The total playback with ANC off can go up to 54 hours, as per OnePlus's claims.

And with ANC on, at 50 per cent volume, the brand says the earbuds will last for 6.5 hours and with the case, they can last as long as 27 hours. Your mileage may vary.

Even if it drops dead, the fast charging support is very useful. After the battery drain test, I plugged them in for some time, and when I checked them, the earbuds had regained 90 per cent

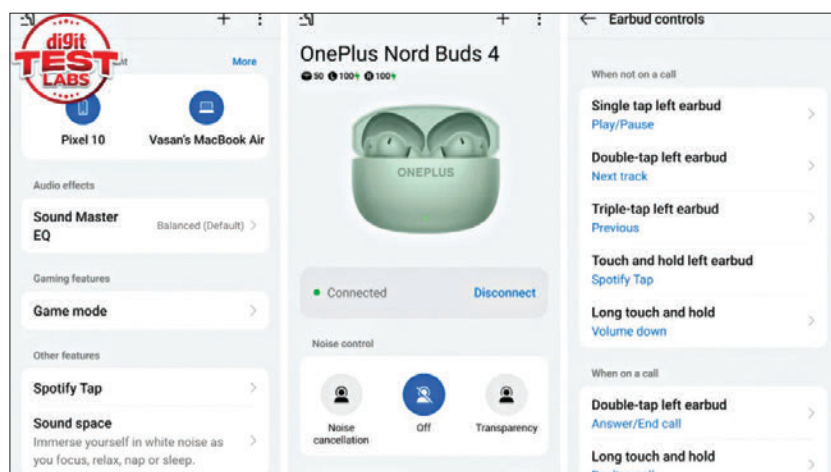


health. The Nord Buds 4 is said to take 55 minutes to fully charge, and the case takes another half an hour.

SOFTWARE EXPERIENCE

The pairing was straightforward and quick. The OnePlus Nord Buds 4 supports Google Fast Pair and Microsoft Swift Pair.

After pairing, you will need the HeyMelody app for controlling the rest of the experience. This app shares the



same simple design philosophy as the earbuds' design. It offers two screens. The main screen shows the remaining battery life and has noise control, dual connection, equaliser, game mode, etc. The second screen offers touch controls, with plenty of customisable gestures for both the left and right earbuds. The earbuds also give Spotify Tap, which lets you quickly launch the streaming app. Since I primarily use Spotify, I liked this integration.

You can configure tap gestures to trigger an AI assistant, and there's also an AI-powered translation feature. These are nice to have.



SHOULD YOU BUY IT?

If you simply compare specifications, the OnePlus Nord Buds 4 don't always come out on top. The Realme Buds Air 8 also edges ahead in areas such as sound detail, transparency mode and active noise cancellation. However, that doesn't mean the Nord Buds 4 is bad.

I had a comfortable experience using it over the past week. This includes the lightweight build of the earbuds, the compactness of the case,

the comely finish of the earbuds and case, reliable battery life, dependable call quality, a breadth of touch controls, and a simple-to-use yet feature-rich HeyMelody app. The sound signature is also easy to listen to across different genres. Even here, you get customisation options so that you can choose based on your taste.

That matter of taste is what makes you choose between the Realme Buds Air 8 and the OnePlus Nord Buds 4. Listeners who enjoy picking apart every layer in a song may prefer the Realme Buds Air 8. Realme also offers a more aggressive noise cancellation and transparency mode. The differences are meagre, though, and if you are a casual listener, you would enjoy the OnePlus earbuds' sound too, if you like a warmer and more relaxed sound profile.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Drivers: 12 mm dynamic driver | Frequency Response: 20 Hz - 20 KHz | Driver Sensitivity: 122 dB@1kHz | Microphones: 6 (3 mics per bud) | Impedance: 28 Ohms | Rated Power: 5 mW | Battery (earbud): 62 mAh | Battery (case): 530 mAh | Connectivity: Bluetooth 6.1 | Codec: AAC, SBC

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